THE DRAFT DELIMITATION RENAMES 19 CONSTITUENCIES AND REDRAWS THE BORDERS OF 28

commission] adopted for the distribution of seats," he says.

There are many theories swirling as to why the commission has proposed this change. Some see elements of the 'Dixon Plan' at play, referring to a 1950s' proposal by United Nations representative Owen Dixon that included clubbing together Muslim-majority Rajouri and Poonch (known as the Pir Panjal region) with the Muslim-majority Kashmir Valley. Others say the move is aimed at breaking the homogeneity of the Kashmir Valley polity. Though both are Muslim-majority regions, the people of the Kashmir Valley and the Pir Panjal region have different ethnic and cultural makeups and different political aspirations. Pir Panjal is populated mostly by Gujjars and Bakerwals, who make up close to 12 per cent of J&K's population.

The areas also have notably different voter turnout rates. The voter turnout in south Kashmir remained below 10 per cent in the last election, while in Pir Panjal, it crossed 65 per cent. As a political analyst points out, this could be a decisive factor in elections. IkkJutt Jammu party president Ankur Sharma, who served as a defence lawyer in the horrific Kathua rape and murder case, dismisses this view, saying it is just a "smokescreen" to hide the BJP's real plan of disempowering Jammu. This view—that the delimitation is aimed at further disempowering the erstwhile J&K—is palpable in Kashmir as well. There, the delimitation is being seen as an attempt to tilt the power balance to allow the BJP to instal a Hindu chief minister. And in the new scheme of things, the Gujjar and Bakerwal communities of Jammu, who despite staying close to the border have traditionally stood by New Delhi, are being seen by the BJP as an essential vote bank. ■

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THE RIGHT WAY IS THE ONLY WAY



In the previous issue, we spoke about over speeding – which is one of the most hazardous activities on Indian roads and which causes frequent accidents. This time around, we will be talking about a violation which seems like it happens every time our motorists and bikers take to the roads - going against traffic.

If you're driving against the flow of traffic and designated lanes, then your vehicle is on what's called "wrong side."

The law clearly states that you should never drive on the wrong side of traffic, no matter how short a distance it is. Wrong side driving is dangerous and cannot be justified. It doesn't matter if you are trying to save fuel or time, the risk of getting into an accident makes it wrong for any situation.

Reversing against oncoming traffic because you overshot your exit or missed a turn is also considered wrong side driving.

CONSEQUENCES OF WRONG SIDE DRIVING



Wrong-side driving can be hazardous to your safety and the safety of those around you. You are heading into oncoming traffic, which means that other vehicles will have to change lanes to bypass and avoid hitting you. This unsafe lane shift can be potentially dangerous.

When it comes to driving on the wrong side at night, many people are unaware of the dangers that can arise from doing so with your car lights on high beam. Full beam lights from both sides can blind drivers and thus increase the chances of an accident significantly.

The other possibility is that when people emerge from intersections, they usually look to the right before merging into traffic. They neglect to inspect the left side, which is completely fine! However, if there is a vehicle approaching from the wrong side, the risk of a collision increases exponentially.

Even pedestrians crossing the road tend to ignore looking on the left side since they don't anticipate traffic coming from that direction.

To curb wrong side driving, the MoRTH has taken serious steps since 2019. The violators are handed out hefty challans (which can go up to Rs 5,000) by the traffic police. There's also a chance of the driving license getting confiscated. Also, as per the amended Motor Vehicles Act, the offenders can even be taken to court.

In other words, by driving on the wrong side, you might not only cause a major accident but also end up spending money paying a fine.

So, be the better guy and saying NO to wrong side driving.